

3. The Survival Gene

Rats scurried along bare concrete walls. Cockroaches congregated in corridors, where we did press-ups and sit-ups to compensate for the lack of a gym. They told us the hotel in Dhaka was structurally sound, though it was half-built and anything above the fifth floor was open to the elements. The beds were damp, and the electrical system made playing *Tiger Woods PGA Tour* on the Xbox a lottery.

Welcome to international cricket, and my first experience of captaining an England team, in the Under-19 World Cup in Bangladesh in 2004. Despite the privations, it was an invaluable four-week crash course in team building and personal resilience. Those sessions, working down from twenty press-ups to two, and back up again, did no one any harm.

When we moved to Chittagong, our hotel was the one in which the senior side refused to stay later that year. We thought it was a palace. We should have done better than lose to the West Indies in the semi-final but cracked under the pressure and were bowled out for 155. It demonstrated how much I had to learn, about both group dynamics and individual obligations. We were so far from being the finished product.

Though I had captained Bedford School, there seemed more chance of making a day trip to Narnia than captaining my country. Samit Patel was our original skipper, but he failed a fitness test and Andy Pick, who coached the squad in conjunction with John Abrahams after taking over from Paul Farbrace, made a brave call in asking me to take over. He wanted to deliver a life lesson to Samit, that talent is only part of the equation.